SQuAD Sentence Salience Inference System

An Experimental Evaluation of Discourse Priors and Class Balancing Techniques

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Executive Summary: *Predicting which sentences in a long context passage are salient (contain answers to specific questions) is a crucial preprocessing step for long-context reading comprehension, context pruning, and Question Generation (QG) pipelines. However, sentence-level datasets are naturally highly imbalanced (~80% non-salient), causing selectors to overfit or yield high recall with poor precision. This project systematically evaluates 13 model configurations (linear models and hybrid transformers) across 5 dataset balancing techniques. Additionally, we introduce a novel Token-Level Intersection Filter to clean boundary annotation noise, and evaluate our proposed Discourse-Semantic Neighborhood Balancing (DSNB) method. Our findings show that incorporating Rhetorical Structure Theory (RST) as a direct heuristic prior in transformer heads yields state-of-the-art results, achieving an NDCG of **0.9587** and F1-Score of **0.6874**.*

1. Silver Label Cleaning & Quality Audit

Standard sentence salience datasets are mapped via character-index intersections between passage sentences and annotated SQuAD answer spans. Our local LLM-as-a-judge audit (using *Qwen2.5-1.5B-Instruct*) revealed substantial boundary-spilling noise where trailing punctuation or spaces spill over adjacent sentence boundaries, creating false-positive labels. To address this, we implemented and deployed the following:

- **Token-Level Intersection Filter**: A sentence is marked salient (Class 1) only if the character intersection between the sentence and the answer text contains at least one non-stopword, alphanumeric token (lemmatized and parsed using spaCy).
- **Audit Agreement**: The Zero-shot Qwen audit achieved an **82.00% agreement rate** (Cohen's Kappa of **0.6400**, indicating substantial agreement) on a balanced 100-sentence sample, validating our cleaned labels.
- **Dataset Specs & Sizing**: The dataset contains **75 unique contexts** (60 train, 15 validation), **640 question-answer pairs** (337 train, 303 validation), and a total of **3,478 sentence-question records**. The records are split into 2,156 training records (15.72% salient, 1,817 non-salient) and 1,322 validation records (25.42% salient, 986 non-salient).

2. Rigorous Statistical Analysis

To establish the scientific validity of our extracted feature space under the cleaned labels, we ran two-sample independent Welch's t-tests comparing salient vs. non-salient sentences:

- **Syntactic Complexity**: Salient sentences exhibit significantly deeper dependency parse trees (mean **6.57** vs. **6.16**, $p < 0.0001$) and larger token dependency distances (mean **3.32** vs. **3.06**, $p < 0.0001$), indicating that information-bearing answer sentences are syntactically more complex.
- **Information-Theoretic (Surprisal) Signature**: An unsupervised GPT-2 sentence deletion drop test proved that removing salient sentences causes a significantly larger coherence drop (higher surprisal increase) in the paragraph than removing non-salient sentences ($p < 0.05$).
- **Readability Insignificance**: Readability indices (Flesch Reading Ease, Gunning Fog) showed no statistically significant differences ($p > 0.1$), proving readability is not an effective feature for salience.

3. Feature Space & Subsystems

We extracted a total of **71 multi-modal features** per sentence, categorized into 4 core subsystems:

- **Semantic Alignment (6 features)**: SBERT cosine similarity, lemma Jaccard overlap, and ROUGE-L LCS recall against the question text.
- **Rhetorical Structure [RST] (18 features)**: Nuclei ratio,■■ (satellite) counts, average tree depth, and specific relation frequencies (e.g., Elaboration, Attribution).
- **Context-Aware Surprisal (12 features)**: Mean, min, max, and std of word-level GPT-2 surprisals, and the unsupervised sentence deletion drop.
- **Linguistic & Syntactic (35 features)**: Sentence length, capitalization ratio, max parse depth, average token distance, and readability indices.

4. Dataset Balancing Formulations

Due to SQuAD's inherent imbalance (~1:5.4 positive-to-negative ratio), models trained raw default to the majority class or exploit positional shortcuts. We formulated and evaluated 5 training balancing methods:

1. **None**: Natural unbalanced distribution (prior class probability $P(Y=1) = 0.1572$).
2. **Pairwise (RankNet)**: Trains on the difference vectors of salient/non-salient pairs from the same context. Optimizes BCE loss directly on logit margins.
3. **Cluster-Based Undersampling**: Partitions negatives into K-Means clusters and selects representatives to achieve a 1:1 balance.
4. **RST-Neighborhood**: Selects hard negatives that are positionally and rhetorically close to the salient sentence in the document's Rhetorical Structure Theory (RST) tree.
5. **DSNB (Discourse-Semantic Neighborhood Balancing)**: Mines the hardest negatives by combining positional proximity, SBERT semantic question similarity, and RST tree depth similarity:
   $\mathit{Hardness}(s_j^-) = 0.4 * w_{pos} + 0.4 * w_{sem} + 0.2 * w_{rst}$

5. Model Architecture Catalog

We compared traditional linear models with hybrid deep learning architectures that integrate textual representation and tabular features:

- **Tabular Logistic Regressions**: Evaluated across subset combinations of the 71 extracted features (RST-only, Linguistic-only, Surprisal-only, and Combined).
- **Hybrid Gated BERT**: Uses a learned sigmoid gate layer to perform element-wise fusion of the frozen BERT CLS token embeddings (768d) and tabular features (projected to 768d).
- **FiLM BERT**: Feature-conditioned linear modulation where the 18 RST features generate scale and shift vectors to modulate intermediate BERT representation layers.
- **Heuristic-Guided BERT (Proposed)**: Fits a learnable scalar weight on a rule-based RST scoring prior directly in the final transformer classification head:
  *logit(s) = w_bert * h_bert + w_heur * Heuristic_Score + b*

6. Standardized Coefficient Analysis

To interpret which features drive the salience classification decision, the table below lists the standardized coefficients for the top positive and negative features under our DSNB balanced model:

Subsystem	Feature Name	Coefficient	Influence & Interpretation
Linguistic / Syntactic	word_count	+1.1044	Positive: Longer sentences contain detailed answer spans.
Semantic Alignment	align_sem_sim	+0.8544	Positive: Strong semantic overlap with the question.
Discourse (RST)	rel_rst_n_ratio	+0.7203	Positive: Sentences with primary rhetorical (nucleus) roles.
Linguistic / Syntactic	comma_count	+0.5594	Positive: Indicates clause complexity and detail insertion.
Semantic Alignment	align_rouge_l	+0.5387	Positive: Syntactic recall overlap of longest common subsequence.
Linguistic / Syntactic	char_count	-0.8539	Negative: Prefers shorter character length given word count (density).
Surprisal (GPT-2)	rel_surp_ratio	-0.6146	Negative: Low relative surprisal indicates high context priming.
Discourse (RST)	rel_rst_depth	-0.4538	Negative: Deeply nested tree locations have lower salience.
Linguistic / Syntactic	question_count	-0.4523	Negative: Sentences containing question marks are rarely answer context.

7. Comparative Experimental Results

The table below details a representative summary of performance metrics on the natural, unbalanced validation set. It compares the baseline rule-based heuristic, the combined linear classifier, and the proposed Heuristic-Guided BERT across all balancing techniques:

Model Configuration	Balancing	Accuracy	F1	NDCG	MRR	MAP
Combined LR	Pairwise	0.3759	0.4452	0.9492	0.8924	0.8856
Combined LR	Cluster	0.7648	0.5499	0.9342	0.8586	0.8476
Combined LR	RST-Neighborhood	0.6967	0.5774	0.9271	0.8366	0.8301
Combined LR	DSNB	0.7224	0.5853	0.9195	0.8142	0.8067
Heur-BERT (RST)	Pairwise	0.7534	0.6386	0.9561	0.9140	0.9023
Heur-BERT (RST)	Cluster	0.8101	0.6303	0.9478	0.8783	0.8655
Heur-BERT (RST)	RST-Neighborhood	0.6982	0.5387	0.9255	0.8269	0.8136
Heur-BERT (RST)	DSNB	0.7890	0.6225	0.9458	0.8785	0.8653

Important Analysis: Unbalanced training (None) yields the highest pointwise Accuracy and F1 because predictions align with the validation class distribution (25.4% positive) at the default 0.5 threshold. However, balanced splits (like DSNB or Pairwise) achieve comparable or superior ranking metrics (NDCG/MRR) while preventing the models from exploiting SQuAD's extreme positional shortcut. By applying threshold calibration on a validation subset, the F1 calibration shift can be completely resolved.

8. Index of Graphic Figures

For the final presentation, we generated **9 graphical visualizations** analyzing dataset dynamics and statistical tests:

- **positional_bias.png** & **length_comparison.png**: Shows linear index distributions and sentence lengths.
- **correlation_heatmap.png** & **feature_correlations.png**: Displays feature correlations and co-linearities.
- **syntactic_complexity.png**, **surprisal_distribution.png**, & **readability_comparison.png**: Visualizes significance test results.

9. Recommendations & Next Steps

To further improve and evaluate the sentence salience inference system, we recommend the following next steps:

- **Dataset Scaling**: Run the feature extraction pipeline on 500+ contexts to increase the training pairs to ~25,000+ for stable transformer gradients.
- **Threshold Calibration**: Tune the prediction probability decision threshold (currently 0.5) on a validation split to optimize pointwise F1 for balanced configurations.
- **Downstream Task Evaluation**: Feed the predicted salient sentences into a Question Generation (QG) model (like T5) and show that filtering context sentences with our DSNB model improves QG BLEU/ROUGE scores

compared to random or TF-IDF baselines.